

SCENARIO 5

IF

The anti-Congress, anti-BJP Third Front gets around **100** seats and the BSP gets **40** and the rest are shared between the UPA and the NDA, the born-again Front will need the support of another **132** MPs to form the government.

$$100 + 40 + 132 = 272$$

Third Front BSP Others

How can they ever grab power?

The first priority of Messrs Karat and gang will be to ensure that the newly-forged bonds of friendship don't suddenly snap and front partners don't fall for the many inducements that are likely to be thrown their way by the two major combines. If the Third Front stays glued together, it is almost certain that neither the UPA nor the NDA will be able to form the government. As happened in 1996 and 1997, they can virtually force the Congress to back their government. How long such a government will last is anybody's guess.

SCENARIO 6

IF

The Congress and the BJP do not together account for the halfway mark of **272** seats, it will leave the field open for the many regional leaders to throw their hats into the ring.

$$120 + 50 + 102 = 272$$

Third Front BSP Others

The question then arises: how do you reconcile their ambitions?

As the leader of the biggest block, Mayawati will feel it is her right to rule, but she is likely to be thwarted from inside. If a consensus among the leaders is elusive, the Third Front and "others" may choose a consensus candidate from the Left. In 1996, Jyoti Basu's unanimous choice was thwarted by the Left parties, which he later termed a "historic blunder". History is waiting to be repeated, this time as a farce.

gional parties, Naidu may not be averse to lead from the front. He would be happy to allow history record him as the second prime minister from Andhra Pradesh. Who wouldn't be?

For the Left, the Third Front is its opportunity to avoid the risk of supporting a Congress-led government, its principal opposition in its traditional strongholds. The CPI(M), facing tough battles in its erstwhile citadels, is hoping to gain from Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh and a few pockets in Orissa, Bihar and Rajasthan. Then there is the big dilemma of choosing between power and power without responsibility. Karat, who once thwarted Jyoti Basu's chances of becoming prime minister by taking on a faction led by then general secretary Harkishen Singh Surjeet, is now under pressure on whether to join the government if the Third Front comes to power. The Bengal unit may press for Buddhadeb and Karat's chances of getting "Surjeeted" are pretty high.

Such scenarios only explain the power of the provincials and the diminishing clout of the so-called national parties. True, the idea of India in the vision of most of these parties is as big as a district—or an imaginary soviet in Kannur or Midnapur. The prime minister himself had trained his guns on regional parties when he blamed them for the backwardness of several states. He said a political party with a "national perspective" was needed for good governance. Uncharitable perhaps, considering the UPA Government had survived on crutches provided by the regional parties. When the Left pulled out, it was another regional party (SP) that came to the rescue.

The Congress' own failure partly explains the fragmentation. While the party failed to keep pace in the states and took the blame for ignoring the development needs of the states, the regional parties emerged as powerful alternatives. The combined strength of the BJP and the Congress in 1999 was 296, the lowest ever since the BJP came into existence. It is at the risk of falling short of half-way mark this

Deve Gowda

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- Is flexible enough to join any front that will come to power, including the BJP-led NDA.
- Organising skills of son and former Karnataka chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy are coming handy.
- He has kept the communication lines with the top Congress leadership open.

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- Local Congress leaders are resisting his efforts for a pre-poll alliance.
- May not gain enough numbers to make a serious claim for prime ministership if the Third Front comes to power.
- Three-cornered fight in the state is not turning out in his favour.



YASBANT NEGI